



Action Stations

Jan Sunwai: The state's general administration department issued a circular for weekly public hearings at every level of the Government. "This will break the perception of government's insularity and bureaucracy will be dealing with people directly," says a key Shivraj aide.

Lease-hold to Free-hold: On August 25, the Government announced conversion of lease-hold Nazul land in cities of the state to free-hold upon payment of 1 per cent of the prevailing market rates.

Stringent Action: A major crackdown is underway in cities like Indore, Bhopal, Gwalior and Jabalpur against errant housing cooperatives that have duped their members by denying them plots. Nearly 1,000 complaints were received by Bhopal administration within a month of the launch of the drive.

a purchase of almost Rs 2,000 crore, only Rs 198 crore—about 10 per cent— of power, was purchased through bidding. A whopping Rs 1,770 crore's worth was bought without any competitive bidding.

In its order on February 16, 2009, the Madhya Pradesh Electricity Regulatory Commission (MPERC) held that there was no transparency in the purchase but only issued a warning to the DISCOMS. Upon a complaint by an NGO, the Lokayukta in September issued notices to DISCOMS for their response, in what the opposition Congress calls one of the biggest scams in the power sector in Madhya Pradesh. "Over the years, losses incurred due to this have not only wiped out the entire equity capital of the licensees but have also forced them to default against payments due from them. In short, these DISCOMS are fast becoming financially sick," warns the MPERC in its tariff order for the current fiscal.

The Congress sniffs its chance as it goes on the offensive against Chouhan on issues like power and alleged corruption in the job guarantee scheme. An Opposition onslaught is one thing but in-house criticism is a serious matter. The disquiet within his cabinet colleagues became evident when they vented their spleen against the intransigence of the bureaucracy at an excursion on the outskirts of Bhopal in July. In this context, an episode concerning a senior minister is illustrative. As a Central team went about digging up irregularities in the implementation of the job guarantee scheme in five districts, Panchayat and Rural Development Minister Bhargava had been writing for the removal of over a dozen chief executive officers of district panchayats, many of them IAS officers, because of the numerous complaints against them. His pleas are yet to be heeded.

That the law of diminishing

returns had hit Shivraj's brand of politics became evident in the May 2009 Lok Sabha elections. After a meteoric rise for three years and the giddy high of last year's assembly elections victory, he was confronted with his first reality check in the Lok Sabha elections earlier this year which saw the Congress improve its tally for the first time to double digits since 1991, winning 11 to the BJP's 16 with one of the 29 seats in Madhya Pradesh going to the BSP. The downslide wasn't precipitous but it was clearly perceptible and necessitated remedial measures.

Chouhan now faces an acid test in the municipal elections slated for 2009-end. The BJP has held sway over the state's urban voters over the last two decades. The five major municipal corporations—Bhopal, Indore, Gwalior, Jabalpur and Ujjain—are held by the party. Only in Bhopal does the directly elected mayor belong to the Congress while the BJP has a majority of corporators. The slip of the party over its captive hold of urban voters was first visible in May 2009 when it lost Ujjain and its margins of victory were reduced to few thousand votes from lakhs in the four major cities.

The race for urban votes has also prompted the Government to crack down on errant housing cooperatives in the cities. For the first time since the mid-90s when the Congress government cracked down the denial of plots to rightful members by their unscrupulous promoters, the political potential of repeating the exercise was realised by the Shivraj Government. This happened when people began approaching police and district officials in Bhopal and Indore with complaints against these bodies during public hearings.

The question is whether the efforts will pay off or not. State Congress President Suresh Pachouri alleges, "This is an eye-wash. People can see that it is all a pre-poll palliative with no long-term commitment." Regardless, Chouhan is trying hard to make up for the lost years of performance on the administrative front. ■